

- Knight said he wanted to ‘**mythologise**’ British working-class lives in the way ‘Americans took 19th century agricultural workers and called them Cowboys and made them heroes of Westerns’.

Some of the gangster conventions that *Peaky Blinders* uses are:

- The importance of **family loyalty** – it doesn’t matter who the enemy is, the Law or other gangs, the Sheldons are devoted to protecting and securing their family. This focus on family dynamics (an element familiar from **soap opera**) is also reminiscent of the US crime drama *The Sopranos*.
- The **protagonist** is a cool, quiet but ambitious **antihero** who uses intelligence and cunning, as well as brutal violence, to ascend the ranks of a criminal family/organisation – or is strategic in order to maintain their position at the top. Tommy Shelby embodies this stock character in *Peaky Blinders* – a man of few words, as he says to Arthur in the first episode; ‘That’s what I do, I *think*.’ His plan to inflate the value of the racehorse, despite Arthur’s concerns, illustrates his ingenuity.
- The **antagonist** is a lawmaker who is investigating the hero and his family/organisation. This is unusual in crime drama as here the investigator threatens the *status quo*, established by the criminals, rather than seeking to preserve it. Often the detective resorts to unorthodox methods, including those as brutal as the gangsters, to achieve results (see Eliot Ness in *The Untouchables*). In *Peaky Blinders*, Campbell is the antagonist in the first season – in episode 1, his ride through Birmingham, righteous sermon to the police and his torture of Arthur, clearly establish him as a **binary opposition** to Tommy.
- Within the criminal family there is usually an older **patriarch/matriarch** around whose power the other characters orbit. Aunt Polly plays this role in *Peaky Blinders*. Another stock gangster genre character is the less smart, more violent sibling of the hero – in this case, Arthur – playing another binary opposition to the protagonist.
- The **narrative** of *Peaky Blinders* is typical of the gangster genre: the power of the criminal family is threatened – by other gangs, by the law, and from threats within – and the main characters must pull together (or sometimes betray each other) to survive.
- Episode 1 of *Peaky Blinders* establishes a number of plots and subplots around these themes. Tommy’s robbery (hidden from Arthur) has backfired and brought Campbell to Birmingham. Meanwhile Communists, the IRA and rival gangs from different ethnic groups are referred to as threats to manifest later in the season. In addition, Grace, an undercover agent, catches Tommy’s eye, opening a possibility of both romance and betrayal.
- In **long form TV drama**, more subplots and characters can be added to add richness and complexity to a more generic narrative. There is space for Aunt Polly, Ada and Freddie, Billy Kimber, the Lee Family, the IRA and even Danny Whizz-Bang to have fully developed narrative arcs all in one season.

Consider the processes through which meanings are established through intertextuality.

- There are numerous references to the **Western** genre in the first 15 minutes of the opening episode. Some of these are: Tommy’s ride through the city streets, the townspeople who dash to hide when he arrives and then linger to watch the drama, the peaceful living room that hides a bustling gambling den, etc.
- The story of a crime family, the power dynamics within it, and their battles with rivals/the law was immortalised in Francis Ford Coppola’s *The Godfather*. The ‘rise of the foot soldier’ narrative arc, from working class to mob boss, references *The Godfather 2*.
- The ‘ruthless enforcer vs mob boss’ set up, as well as the 1920s setting and costume (especially flat caps), recall *The Untouchables*.